



Safe guard: Ecuador will come into the World Cup as a firm favourite to make it to the next round. Though the team's offence is not as menacing as Argentina or Colombia its defence has been clinical. GETTY IMAGES

mostly of players nurtured in the Netherlands, carrying the hopes of the smallest nation by population to ever play in the tournament.

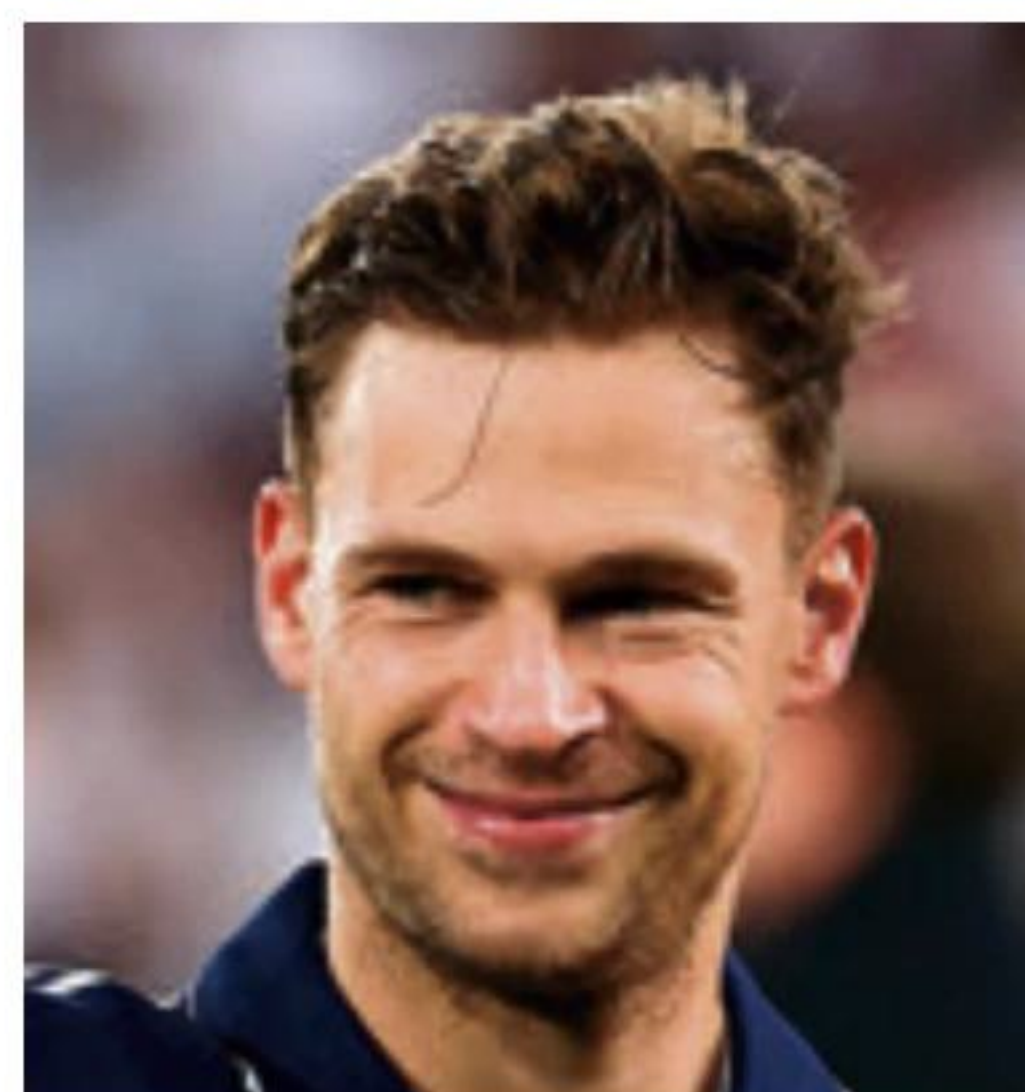
The team features some exciting youngsters like Tahith Chong — Manchester United's Jimmy Murphy Young Player of the Year winner in 2017–18 — and Sontje Hansen, the highest goalscorer in the FIFA U-17 World Cup 2019, then playing for the Dutch. And the experience of veteran coach Dick Advocaat made Curacao a dark horse in CONCACAF qualifying as the team scored 28 goals in 10 matches, conceding a paltry five.

Advocaat had led the Dutch to the World Cup quarterfinals in the United States of America in 1994. Now that he returns to America as the tournament's oldest-ever coach — at 78 — he will look to script another inspirational tale, this time one about the underdogs.

Meanwhile, Ecuador will come into the World Cup as a firm favourite to make it to the next round. Though the team's offence is not as menacing as Argentina or Colombia — the South American sides with most goals in the 2026 World Cup qualifiers — its defence has been clinical.

In its qualification campaign, Ecuador let in just five goals in 18 matches, the fewest among CONMEBOL sides. The partnership between Willian Pacheco and Piero Hincapié,

ON THE RADAR



Joshua Kimmich (Germany)

Germany is stacked with youngsters, but the centre of the team inevitably will be the pivot from Bayern Munich. The 31-year-old has been versatile, switching between full-back and holding midfielder. While Florian Wirtz and Jamal Musiala will dictate the attack, Kimmich is expected to play the role of a modern libero, tracking back and often orchestrating play in midfield.



Tahith Chong (Curacao)

The former Manchester United winger may have had a bland stint with Sheffield United this season (22 appearances, one assist), but his national team stats — three goals, one assist in five appearances — paint a different picture. His pace along the flanks and ability to thread through balls into the final third could become Curacao's key strategy in attack.